PSU RECRUITMENT EXAM

Copying Scams Go Hi-tech

By Rohit Parihar



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

It was believed to be a foolproof offline digital system for recruitment exams. But as the actual test unfolded on January 5—for 186 vacancies in the National Seeds Corporation Limited (NSC)—it turned out to be easily penetrable with remote access software. The Rajasthan Police have arrested 14 people, six candidates among them, in connection with this first-of-a-kind cheating racket, raising fresh concerns about the integrity of digital examinations being held for numerous government jobs and college admissions in India.

Digital devices such as wireless earbuds have long been known to be used for copying; occasional reports of hacking too have marred online tests. But in this case, investigators discovered a significant oversight: what was thought to be a secure test conducted on an exclusive server was, in fact, accessible via the internet. "This exposes a critical lack of understanding about digital security," says V.K. Singh, additional director general of Rajasthan Police's Special Operations Group (SOG). Singh highlighted inadequate security measures at "computer labs" hosting such exams. These third-party testing centres, according to him, often fail to conduct pre-test audits, leaving systems open to tampering.

In all, 28,500 candidates had appeared for the test in three shifts at 60 centres across India. The NSC and the testing agency, says Singh, were already receiving tip-offs about possible cheating, following which six centres in Jaipur, where 3,510 candidates took the test, were marked as "high risk". While the agency had deployed its supervisors at the centres, a core monitoring team remotely noticed something strange: a few computers where candidates had logged in sat idle for unusually long periods before cursors started moving—on their own. The SOG undercover team and supervisors moved swiftly and confirmed that answers were being ticked without any visible action from the candidates. Videographic evidence was captured, suspects detained and computers seized.

The local police, in tandem, conducted raids that revealed how the "solvers" sitting offsite were cracking the answers by leveraging AI tools and transmitting them directly to the compromised computers. The middlemen had allegedly collaborated with lab owners to instal remote access software on these computers where specific candidates were supposed to sit. Investigators have found 1,000 such compromised computers, raising suspicions that as many candidates could have paid hefty amounts to crack the exam fraudulently.

The gang is suspected to have employed similar tactics in a Railway Protection Force test in December 2024. Even as the ongoing probe is expected to lead to further arrests, the latest bust underscores the need for advanced security protocols and heightened accountability to outpace the ingenuity of cheating syndicates. ■

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- **Remote access software installed on specific computers to bypass exclusive servers in connivance with testing centre owners**
- **Offsite "solvers" cracked questions instantly using AI tools. Answers auto-filled without candidates making any input**